

PREHISTORY – 600CE

FROM FUNCTION TO IDENTITY

For Scythian nomads in Asia, Sumerians in Mesopotamia (now Iraq), Nubians in Africa, and the earliest Chinese dynasty, the picture of early clothing continues to emerge from archaeological sites. Although little cloth survives, there are impressions of prehistoric textiles in pottery, and bone sewing needles, reindeer horn buttons, amber necklaces, and wooden weaving sticks are found. Where animal and vegetal fibres exist, they suggest that rudimentary clothes, skins, and furs were largely uncut and often unsewn, fixed by a pin or a tie-cord. When warp-weighted looms came into use, possibly as early as the Neolithic period, a semicircle or T-shaped tunic could be woven. Textile technology determined the shape and degree of stretch, durability, and warmth of garments. Stitching was used to strengthen garments, for decoration, and to express identity. Climate and lifestyle also dictated attire – for example, nomadic Steppe men and women wore trousers for riding.

HELMETS

The earliest helmets were of leather, followed by metal helmets, fashioned first from bronze and then iron. Ancient helmets could be simple conical or hemispherical shapes, or more elaborate, with additional guards for the nose, cheeks, and neck. Helmets provided protection, but also an opportunity for decoration and display, with detailing on the metalwork, such as animal motifs, or topped with crests. Celtic crests could be extremely tall, and warriors were known to fix figural metal pieces, feathers, or horsehair plumes to their helmets. Some intricately patterned and adorned helmets were created solely for ceremonial purposes.



A Celtic Iron Age horned helmet 150–50BCE, made from riveted sheet bronze pieces. It may originally have been adorned with red glass.

Sardinian chieftain A tribal chieftain is shown wearing a cloak in this 7th century BCE bronze statuette from Sardinia. He is armed with a dagger across his chest and a sword and holds a staff. The cloak gave the body some protection while leaving the arms free for fighting.



Scythian rider A Scythian on horseback is shown in a detail from a 5th–4th-century BCE carpet discovered in the frozen tombs of Pazyryk, Siberia. Made of coloured felt, the shapes are stylized, but show the saddle, patterned cape, close-fitting garments, and distinctive moustache and hairstyle.